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Jairus

A synagogue ruler who fell at Jesus' feet for his dying daughter and learned to "only believe."

Jairus was "one of the rulers of the synagogue" in a town by the Sea of Galilee. He was a respected man, but when his twelve-year-old daughter lay dying, he pushed through the crowd and fell at Jesus' feet. Jesus went with him. Then came a delay, as Jesus stopped to heal a woman who touched his clothes. While they waited, word came that the girl had died. Jesus turned to Jairus and said, "Be not afraid, only believe." At the house he took the girl by the hand and raised her to life. Matthew, Mark and Luke all tell the story. It is a story about a desperate parent, an unwelcome delay, and trust in Jesus when all hope seems gone.

At a glance

Name	Jairus, the Greek form of the Old Testament name Jair
Position	"One of the rulers of the synagogue" (Mark 5:22)
Family	A wife and "one only daughter, about twelve years of age" (Luke 8:42; Mark 5:40)
Home	A town by the Sea of Galilee, probably Capernaum
When	c. AD 28–29, during Jesus' ministry in Galilee
Key people	Jesus; Peter, James and John; a woman healed on the way
Main passages	Mark 5:21–43; Matthew 9:18–26; Luke 8:40–56

"As soon as Jesus heard the word that was spoken, he saith unto the ruler of the synagogue, Be not afraid, only believe."

Mark 5:36, KJV

The life of Jairus

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. Matthew tells the story more briefly. There, the ruler says at the start that his daughter "is even now dead" (Matthew 9:18).

- c. AD 28–29

By the sea

Falls at Jesus' feet

When Jesus crosses back over the lake, a crowd gathers. Jairus comes, falls at his feet, and begs him to come and lay hands on his little daughter, who "lieth at the point of death." *Mark 5:21–23*
- On the way

A delay

A woman who has suffered bleeding for twelve years touches Jesus' garment and is healed. Jesus stops, asks who touched him, and speaks with her while Jairus waits. *Mark 5:24–34*
- On the way

Bad news

Messengers arrive from Jairus's house: "Thy daughter is dead: why troublest thou the Master any further?" Jesus tells Jairus not to be afraid, but only to believe. *Mark 5:35–36*
- At the house

Laughed to scorn

Jesus lets only Peter, James and John follow him. He tells the loud mourners that the child "is not dead, but sleepeth," and they laugh at him. *Mark 5:37–40*
- At the house

Talitha cumi

With the parents and the three disciples, Jesus takes the girl's hand and tells her to arise. She gets up and walks. He orders them to tell no one and to give her something to eat. *Mark 5:40–43*

Group notes

Key activities

Mark and Luke tell Jairus's story wrapped around the healing of the woman with the issue of blood. Both stories involve the number twelve, and Jesus calls the woman "Daughter" (Mark 5:34). Many readers see the link as deliberate.

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- 1 **Humbled himself.** A synagogue ruler fell at the feet of a travelling teacher in front of the crowd. *Mark 5:22*
 - 2 **Pleaded for his daughter.** He begged Jesus earnestly to come and lay his hands on her, that she might live. *Mark 5:23*
 - 3 **Waited.** He stood by while Jesus stopped to find and speak with the woman who had touched him. *Mark 5:30-34*
 - 4 **Kept believing.** When the news of death came, he heard Jesus' word, "Be not afraid, only believe," and went on with him. *Mark 5:35-37*
 - 5 **Witnessed the miracle.** He and his wife watched Jesus raise their daughter, and they were "astonished with a great astonishment." *Mark 5:40-42*
 - 6 **Was told to keep quiet.** Jesus charged them that no one should know it, and told them to feed her. *Mark 5:43*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jairus.

Old Testament

Echoes	Elijah raises the son of the widow of Zarephath (1 Kings 17:17–24). Elisha raises the son of the Shunammite woman (2 Kings 4:18–37). In both stories the prophet goes into a private room with the child.
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New Testament

Mark 5:21–43	The fullest account, with the Aramaic words Jesus spoke.
Matthew 9:18–26	A shorter account that calls him "a certain ruler."
Luke 8:40–56	Luke names him and says she was his only daughter.
Echoes	Jesus raises a widow's son at Nain (Luke 7:11–15) and Lazarus of Bethany (John 11:43–44). Peter later says "Tabitha, arise" to Dorcas (Acts 9:40), words close to Jesus' own.

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jesus say to Jairus when the bad news came (Mark 5:36)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Mark places the woman's healing in the middle of Jairus's story?
3. *Apply:* Jairus had to wait while Jesus helped someone else. How do you respond when God seems to delay?
4. *Apply:* Jairus came to Jesus for his child. Who is one person you will pray for by name every day this week?